### Specifications (FG-1D)

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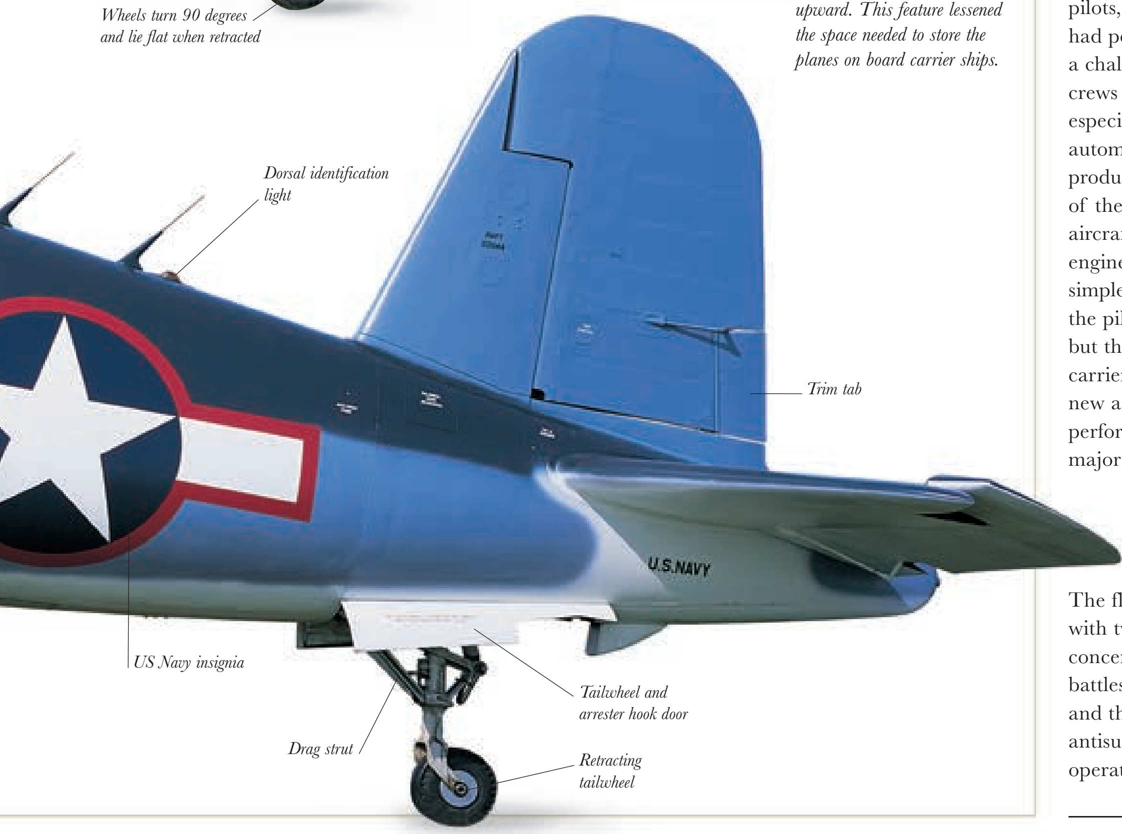
|---|---|
| **Engine** 2,300hp Pratt &Whitney R-2800-32W air-cooled 18-cylinder radial | |
| **Wingspan** 41ft (12.5m) | |
| **Length** 33ft 6in (10.2m) | |
| **Weight** 9,683lb (4,392kg) | |
| **Top speed** 470mph (756kph) | **Crew** 1 |
| **Armament** 4 x 20mm wing-mounted cannons; 2,000lb (907kg) bombload | |


**SINGLE SEAT**
*The cockpit of the F4U Corsair contains one seat only. For a single-seat fighter, this plane features an exceptionally powerful engine.*


**SPACE SAVER**
*The design of the Corsair F4U includes wings that fold upward. This feature lessened the space needed to store the planes on board carrier ships.*




these heavy carriers, new light carriers, and escort carriers, were coming into service. By the fall of 1943, the Americans had 19 carriers of all kinds in the Pacific, and the production drive was continuing at pace.

There would be no point in having carriers without the aircraft to fly off them and the trained pilots to fly the aircraft. The size of the US naval air program was prodigious – the number of new airplanes needed was initially set at 27,500. To cope with pilot training on an unprecedented scale, the navy pioneered the use of flight simulators, primitive by today's standards but good enough to allow trainees to develop the skills for deck landing, takeoff, and instrument flying far more quickly and safely than had been possible before. The mass production of a new generation of naval aircraft – the Grumman TBF Avenger torpedo-bomber, the Vought F4U Corsair and Grumman F6F Hellcat fighters, and the Curtiss SB2C Helldiver to replace the Dauntless dive-bomber – required tough, practical decisions. It was no use producing an aircraft with optimal performance if it could not be cranked out in sufficient numbers with the available factories and machine tools. It is a tribute to the American genius for organization that airplanes and pilots were ready for the new carriers as they rolled off the production lines.

Not all of the new aircraft were an instant success. The Helldiver was disliked by many pilots, still attached to their old Dauntlesses that had performed so well at Midway. Helldivers were a challenge for both their pilots and maintenance crews – they were complex and often faulty, especially when they had been produced by automobile companies roped in to aircraft production for the war effort. The first version of the Corsair had a glaring defect as a carrier aircraft, in that pilots could not see over the engine as they attempted to land on deck. A simple solution was eventually found by raising the pilot's seat and cockpit canopy by 6in (16cm), but the Corsair was not authorized to fly off carriers until April 1944. Yet together, these new aircraft marked a giant stride forward in performance that was unmatched by comparable major advances on the Japanese side.

## The Pacific offensive

By 1944 the United States was ready for a Pacific offensive spearheaded by carriers. The fleet was organized into carrier task groups, with two or three carriers sailing at the center of concentric circles composed of first cruisers and battleships providing a screen of antiaircraft fire, and then destroyers, primarily responsible for antisubmarine defense. A number of task groups operating together, known as a fast carrier force,